

ENGINEERING MANAGEMENT FOR ENGINEERS

Engineering managers combine their engineering knowledge with management expertise to lead teams of specialists for activities like planning, organising, and managing production. The breadth of opportunity that engineering management offers is perhaps one of its most attractive facets



■ **MONIKA BHATI WITH INPUTS FROM JALAJA RAMANUNNI**

Engineering professionals joining manufacturing companies sometimes grow to become engineering managers or require managerial skills at some point of their career. They may have had plenty of engineering training, but they have to frequently learn management skills too once they are on the job. Although it's not a very effective way to develop managerial abilities, the fact remains that these professionals learn to manage through trial and error.

For this, they need to know both the subjects well—technology and

management. Their knowledge of technology falls into place when they apply their managerial skills. The scientific background helps them understand better how to optimise resources and develop innovations in technology. This is why MBA by itself is not suited for engineering management. Rather, the students need to learn management in a technical scenario. The course is very popular in the US but not many are aware of its existence in India.

Let's understand the field

Engineering management primarily deals with optimisation of work systems. This includes improving the efficiency and effectiveness in manu-

facturing as well as service sectors. Engineering management programmes typically include human resource management, industrial psychology, mathematical modeling and optimisation, quality control and operations research.

In the aftermath of globalisation, companies are increasingly looking for performance improvement in order to remain competitive in the market. In this backdrop, the demand for this discipline should only go up with time.

The job outlook in engineering management is good and there is a big scope for growth as most companies are short of managers with technical insight. "I personally believe that com-